

⚠ COMMON MISTAKES “USED TO” AND THE PAST CONTINUOUS

When talking about habits in the past, “used to” should be used. It is incorrect to use the past continuous in this context.

We **used to play** lots of board games when we were younger. ✓

We **were playing** lots of board games when we were younger. ✗

The past continuous shouldn't be used to talk about past habits.

15.2 ANOTHER WAY TO SAY “USED TO” WITH HABITS

“Used to” can be replaced by “would” in writing and formal speech, but only to talk about past habits. These statements often include a reference to time to describe when, or how often something happened.



FURTHER EXAMPLES



When I was little, we **would** go for a picnic every Saturday.



Whenever there were sports on TV, we just **wouldn't** do our homework.



When I was a student in college, I **would** spend as little as possible.



Before I moved abroad, I **wouldn't** try anything new.

⚠ COMMON MISTAKES “WOULD” WITH STATES

“Would” cannot be used to talk about states in the past. “Used to” must be used instead.

We **used to live** in London before we moved to Sydney. ✓

We **would live** in London before we moved to Sydney. ✗

“Would” cannot be used in this way with state verbs.